

FAWCAN HUSAIN



Housing a Divide

MUMBAI It is a divided house in Maharashtra. Days after the BJP leadership succeeded in cooling down an angry Gopinath Munde, it is now Revenue Minister Narayan Rane who has allegedly threatened to step down from his ministerial post. With rumours of Chief Minister Vilasrao Deshmukh's ouster doing the rounds, Rane, who has been eyeing the top job in the Government, is believed to be stepping up pressure on the Congress leader-

ship for the chief minister's chair.

The former problem child of the Shiv Sena is, increasingly, becoming a liability for the Congress with his continued tirade against Deshmukh. Only a few months ago, Rane had openly blamed Deshmukh saying that the Government was "functioning only for one person". State leaders agree that the quality of governance has deteriorated and Deshmukh has not been an effective chief minister,

UP IN REVOLT: Rane but advise against a public fall out. Says Congress leader Sanjay Nirupam, "Elections are coming up next year, and we should bury our differences and work in the interests of the party and the state."

The season of discontent and rebellion began with the Shiv Sena three years ago and has spread to other parties in the state. Rane, and then Raj Thackeray, quit after differences with Sena leader Uddhav Thackeray. Rane, who was welcomed by the Congress for increasing its numbers in the Assembly, is now causing problems for the party by revolting against Deshmukh. The Congress and the Nationalist Congress Party quietly nurtured Raj to weaken the Sena. But post February violence orchestrated by Raj against north Indians and the government's tepid response, the ruling parties have been left red-faced. The BJP, too, is witnessing factionalism with the Nitin Gadkari and Munde camps up in arms against each other.

by Aditi Pal

SIGNPOSTS

DEFERRED: Sarabjit Singh's hanging in Pakistan by 21 days. He was sentenced to death for his alleged role in four blasts in Lahore and Multan in 1990.



NAMED: Steel tycoon Lakshmi Mittal as the richest man in Britain, worth £27.7 billion, by London's *The Sunday Times*.

WON: By Meera Chettri, the bronze medal in the women's lightweight category in the 18th Asian Senior Taekwondo Championship at Zhengzhou, China.

DIED: Tribhuvan Singh, Hindi writer and former vice-chancellor of Mahatma Gandhi Kashi Vidyapeeth in Varanasi. He was 84.

DIED: Babu Parmanand, 76, former governor of Haryana, former Speaker of the Jammu and Kashmir Assembly and a minister in Farooq Abdullah's cabinet in 1982.

VIS-A-VIS SONIA GANDHI Congress president **versus** SITARAM YECHURY CPI(M) Politburo member

I am with the people of Nandigram who faced SORROW and hardship. The law and order machinery didn't work properly.



The Congress should explain how it was part of a grand alliance with Trinamool, Maoists and RSS-BJP elements in Nandigram.

EPILOGUE: While parties squabble over the politics of the issue, people of Nandigram still suffer.